FOR ANYONE WHO LOST THEIR JOB

"Why Did You Leave?"

The 30-second answer that gets laid-off people hired again. For everyone who freezes when the interviewer asks what happened.

Inside: the 30-second layoff answer · explaining a résumé gap · 14 tough follow-up questions · confidence before the interview · printable worksheets & email templates

“Why Did You Leave?” The 30-Second Answer That Gets Laid-Off People Hired Again

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The people in this book are composite examples. Their names and details are made up, but their situations are the ones that come up again and again for people who’ve been laid off.

This book gives general advice about job interviews. It isn’t legal, financial or medical advice, and nobody can promise you a job offer. What it can do is help you show up prepared, honest and calm. That part is up to you, and it’s more than enough.

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Before you start

You probably bought this book because you have an interview coming up. Maybe it's next week. Maybe it's tomorrow morning and you're reading this at 11 at night with a cold cup of tea next to you.

Either way, there's one moment you keep replaying in your head.

The interview is going fine. You've shaken hands, you've talked about the job, you've even made the interviewer laugh once. Then they glance down at your résumé, look back up, and ask:

"So what happened at your last job?"

And your mind goes blank. Or worse, it doesn't go blank. It floods. You start explaining the restructuring, the new director who came in, the way they did it on a Tuesday over a video call, how you'd been there six years, how it wasn't fair. You hear yourself talking for two minutes about something you meant to cover in one sentence. You watch the interviewer's face get politely neutral. And on the drive home you think: *that's where I lost it.*

This book is about that moment, and about everything around it.

I'm not going to tell you that being laid off is a blessing in disguise or that everything happens for a reason. Losing a job is a real loss. It hits your income, your routine, your sense of who you are, and sometimes your pride harder than you expected. If you're angry, that's normal. If you're embarrassed, that's normal too. If you've applied to forty jobs and heard back from three, you're not imagining how hard it is.

What I will tell you is this: **the layoff itself is rarely what costs people the next job. How they talk about it is.**

Interviewers aren't scared of candidates who were laid off. They meet them all the time. Plenty of them have been laid off themselves. What makes them hesitate is a candidate who seems shaken, bitter, evasive, or so eager that it feels like they'd take any job at all. Those are all things you can fix, and most of them you can fix this week.

How to use this book

If your interview is **tomorrow**, read Chapter 2 and Chapter 3, write your answer using the worksheet in the Toolkit at the back, and skim Chapter 10. That's about an hour. It'll make a real difference.

If you have **a few days**, read the whole thing in order. It's short on purpose. Then do the worksheets. Then practise out loud. I'll keep reminding you to practise out loud, because it's the single thing that separates people who *know* their answer from people who can actually *say* it under pressure.

If you're **still searching** and don't have an interview yet, read it now anyway. You'll write your answers while you're calm, which is much easier than writing them the night before.

One rule before we start. Everything in this book assumes you're telling the truth. I'll help you choose your words, choose your emphasis and leave out what doesn't belong. I won't help you invent a story, because invented stories fall apart on the first follow-up question, and then the problem isn't your layoff anymore. It's your honesty.

The good news is you don't need to invent anything. The truth, said well, works.

1. The part nobody talks about

Most interview advice starts with techniques. I want to start one step earlier, because the techniques don't work if this part is still raw.

When people get laid off, they usually go through some version of the same few feelings. Not in a neat order, and not once. They come back, especially the night before an interview.

Shock. Even when everyone saw it coming, it's strange when it actually happens. One day you have a badge and a login and a calendar full of meetings. The next day you don't.

Anger. At the company, at a specific manager, at the people who kept their jobs, sometimes at yourself for not leaving earlier.

Shame. This one is the sneakiest. You know, logically, that layoffs are business decisions. But some part of you still wonders what people think. You avoid telling old colleagues. You change the subject at family dinners. You feel like there's a mark on you.

Doubt. *If I was really good, would they have let me go?* That question can grow very loud after a few weeks of rejections.

Here's why this matters for your interview. **Whatever you haven't dealt with comes out in your voice.**

Anger comes out as a little edge when you mention your old employer. Shame comes out as over-explaining, apologising, or rushing past the topic so fast that it sounds like you're hiding something. Doubt comes out as hedging. "I think I was pretty good at… I mean, I tried to…"

Interviewers don’t need to know what you’re feeling to notice that something is off. They just notice that the answer doesn’t sit right. And when an answer doesn’t sit right, people fill in the blanks themselves, usually with something worse than the truth.

You don’t have to be “over it”

I’m not going to ask you to be at peace with what happened. That can take months. You only need to get to a place where you can talk about it **calmly for thirty seconds**. That’s a much smaller goal, and you can reach it on purpose.

Three things help.

Write the angry version first. Before you write your interview answer, take ten minutes and write down everything you’d say if there were no consequences. What they did wrong. What was unfair. Who you blame. Don’t hold back. Then close the notebook or delete the file. You’re not going to use any of it. The point is to get it out of your system so it doesn’t sneak into the version you *do* use.

Separate the decision from your value. Write down three things you did in your last job that you’re genuinely proud of. Specific things: a project, a customer you turned around, a process you fixed, a person you trained. Those things happened. The layoff doesn’t undo them. You’ll need these later anyway, so you might as well write them now.

Say it out loud to someone safe. A friend, a partner, your mum, your dog. “I was laid off in March when the company cut the operations team.” Say it until it stops feeling like a confession and starts feeling like a fact. Because that’s what it is.

Sara worked in marketing at a software company for five years. When her team was cut, she was furious, mostly because she'd just launched a campaign that beat its targets. In her first two interviews, she spent so long explaining the campaign and how the layoff "made no sense" that she ran out of time to talk about what she wanted next. She didn't get either job.

Before her third interview, she did the angry-version exercise. Two full pages. Then she wrote one sentence: *"My whole team was cut in a restructuring in January, a few weeks after I'd launched a campaign that beat its lead target by 30%."* Same facts. No edge. She got a second interview.

Nothing about Sara's situation changed between interview two and interview three. Only how she carried it.

2. What the interviewer is actually checking

When an interviewer asks why you left your last job, it feels personal. It feels like they're poking at a bruise. But from their side of the table, it's a fairly routine question, and they're listening for three specific things.

You can think of them as three silent questions behind the spoken one.

Silent question 1: "Was this about your performance?"

This is the big one. A layoff because the company cut costs is a non-issue for most employers. Being let go because you couldn't do the job is a different story. The interviewer wants to know which one it was, and they usually can't ask directly without sounding rude.

So they listen for clues. Was it a group of people or just you? Is there a business reason? Does the candidate mention anything they achieved? Does the candidate sound confident or defensive?

Your job is to answer this question before they have to ask it. A short phrase like "the whole team was cut" or "my position was eliminated when they closed that division" does most of the work. A concrete achievement does the rest.

Silent question 2: "Are you honest with me?"

Interviewers have heard every version of every story. They're not trying to catch you out, but they are paying attention to whether your answer sounds straight. Vague answers make people suspicious. So do answers that sound

rehearsed in a slippery way, or that change slightly when they ask a follow-up.

Plain, specific facts sound honest. “In March, the company cut about 15% of staff. My team of eight was reduced to three, and I was one of the five who left.” That’s clear, it’s checkable, and there’s nothing to dig into.

Silent question 3: “Are you going to bring that baggage here?”

Nobody wants to hire someone who’s still fighting their last job. If you criticise your old company, the interviewer isn’t thinking “how awful for you.” They’re thinking “what will this person say about *us* in two years?”

They also want to know you’re looking forward. Are you excited about this role, or just relieved to be offered anything?

So the best answers are short, factual, and end on the future. That’s not a coincidence. It’s the shape that answers all three silent questions at once.

What they mostly *don’t* care about

It helps to know what you can stop worrying about.

They generally don’t care about the inside politics of your old company. They don’t need the timeline of who said what in which meeting. They don’t need to hear how unfair it was, even if it was. They don’t need your severance details or your feelings about your old manager.

They do care about your skills, your results, how you work with people, and whether you want *this* job.

So the layoff should take up as little of the interview as possible. Not because it’s shameful, but because it’s not the interesting part of you.

3. Your 30-second answer

This is the heart of the book. If you only take one thing from it, take this chapter.

Your answer to “Why did you leave?” or “What happened at your last job?” should have three parts and take about thirty seconds. Some people call this kind of structure a formula. I’d rather you think of it as a path you walk down every time: **what happened, why it wasn’t about you, and where you’re going now.**

Part 1: What happened

One sentence. Plain facts. No warm-up.

The mistake almost everyone makes is starting with a run-up. “So, well, it’s a bit of a long story, um, basically there were some changes at the company…” By the time you get to the actual fact, the interviewer has already decided something went wrong.

Just say it.

> *“I was part of a layoff in April when the company cut its customer support team.”*

> *“My role was eliminated after we were acquired by a larger company that already had someone doing the same job.”*

> *“The startup I worked for ran out of funding in February and let most of the team go.”*

That’s it. It feels too blunt when you write it down. It doesn’t sound blunt when you say it calmly. It sounds confident.

Part 2: Why it wasn’t about you

One sentence that answers silent question number one. The best way to do this isn’t to *say* you were good. It’s to *show* it with something specific.

Weak: “I was a really good employee and I always worked hard.”

Strong: “In my last year there I brought our average ticket resolution time down from two days to under one.”

Weak: “It wasn’t a performance thing.”

Strong: “The whole department went, including our director.”

You only need one of these. Either a fact about the scale of the layoff, or a fact about your results. If you have both, pick the result. Results are more interesting.

Part 3: Where you’re going now

One or two sentences that turn the conversation towards this job. This is the part people forget, and it’s the part that makes the biggest difference. It answers silent question three. It tells them you’re not stuck in the past.

> *“Since then I’ve been looking specifically for a support role at a growing company, because I enjoyed building processes more than anything else, and that’s a big part of this job.”*

> *“It actually gave me the push to focus on logistics planning, which is what I was best at, and that’s why this role jumped out at me.”*

Then stop talking.

This is hard. When you're nervous, silence feels dangerous, so you keep going. You add a detail, then a justification, then an apology. Don't. Say your three parts, smile, and let them ask the next question. A calm pause after a clear answer is one of the most confident things you can do in an interview.

Putting it together

Here's a full answer, spoken at a normal pace. Time it if you like. It's about 25 seconds.

> *"I was part of a layoff in April, when the company cut its customer support team from twelve people to four. In my last year there I'd brought our average resolution time down from two days to under one, so I'm proud of what I left behind. Since then I've been looking for a role where I can build support processes at a company that's growing, which is exactly what drew me to this one."*

Notice what's not in there. No blame. No apology. No "unfortunately." No story about the director. No explanation of why they chose four people to keep. Nothing for the interviewer to dig into, because there's nothing hidden.

Rewriting a bad answer

Let's look at the kind of answer people give when they haven't prepared, and fix it step by step.

The unprepared answer:

"Yeah, so, that's a good question. Basically the company was going through a lot of changes. We got a new CEO about a year ago and he had a very different vision, and honestly a lot of us didn't really agree with the direction. Then in March they announced restructuring, and they did it pretty badly to be honest, it was just a 15-minute call. I'd been there six years so it was a bit of a shock. I think they were mainly trying to cut costs before selling the company. But anyway, I'm looking for something new now."

What's wrong with it? It opens with a stall. It talks about disagreeing with leadership (warning sign). It criticises how the layoff was handled (more baggage). It mentions the shock (emotion). It speculates about the company's motives (not your business anymore). And it ends with "I'm looking for something new," which says nothing about *this* job.

Now the rewrite:

The prepared answer:

"After six years there, my role was one of about forty cut in a restructuring in March. In that time I'd grown from coordinator to managing the regional supplier accounts, and I renegotiated contracts that saved around €200,000 a year. What I want next is a bigger procurement role at a company that's investing in its supply chain, and from what I've read about your expansion, that's what's happening here."

Same person. Same facts. Completely different impression.

How to make it sound like you

The examples in this book are deliberately neutral. If you copy them word for word, they'll sound a bit like a script, because they are one. Here's how to make yours sound natural:

- **Use your own words for your job.** If you'd say "I ran the warehouse night shift," don't say "I was responsible for overseeing nocturnal logistics operations."
- **Keep one detail that's specific to you.** A number, a customer type, a tool you used. Specific details make you sound real.
- **Write it down, then say it, then rewrite it the way you said it.** Spoken language is shorter and looser than written language. Your answer should sound like speech.
- **Practise it five times out loud.** Not in your head. Out loud. The first time will feel awkward. By the fifth, it'll feel like something you'd actually say.

There's a worksheet for this in the Toolkit at the back. Use it.

4. When your story is messy

Chapter 3 works beautifully when your situation is clean: big layoff, whole team, nothing complicated. Real life is often messier. Maybe only you and one other person were let go. Maybe it wasn't really a layoff. Maybe you quit before they could push you. Maybe this is your second layoff in two years.

This chapter goes through the messy versions one by one. The principle stays the same in every case: **be honest about the fact, be brief, and put the weight of your answer on what you learned or what you're doing now.**

"Only a few of us were let go"

This is the situation that makes people most nervous, because it invites the question *why you?*

Don't wait for that question. Answer it inside your main answer, using whatever the real criteria were. Companies usually cut based on something: which projects survived, which locations stayed open, seniority, cost of the role, or a team being merged.

> *"The company reduced my team from six to three. They kept the people working on the product line they were continuing, and I'd been on the one they decided to close. My manager is one of my references, and she's happy to talk about my work."*

That last sentence is gold if it's true. Offering a reference from the manager who was there when you left tells the interviewer more than any explanation could. If you parted on good terms with your manager, ask them now whether

they'll be a reference. Most people say yes.

If you honestly don't know why you were chosen, don't guess and don't speculate. Say what you do know.

> *"They didn't share the individual criteria, but it was part of a wider cost-cutting round. My reviews in the two years before were strong, and I'm happy to share them."*

"Honestly, I was let go for performance"

If you were fired, or "managed out," don't call it a layoff. This feels tempting, but it's the one thing in this book I'd ask you never to do. A reference check or a single follow-up question can expose it, and then the interviewer stops trusting anything else you said.

You can be honest without making it the headline. The structure is: own it briefly, explain the mismatch, show what you've done about it.

> *"Honestly, the role wasn't the right fit. It was much more focused on cold sales than I'd understood when I joined, and after eight months we agreed it wasn't working. It taught me a lot about what I'm good at. I'm strongest when I'm managing existing customers and growing those accounts, which is why I'm applying for account management roles like this one."*

Notice that this answer doesn't grovel and doesn't blame. It treats the firing as useful information about fit. That's a mature way to see it, and interviewers respect it.

If the issue was something you've genuinely worked on, say so with specifics. "I've since done a course in Excel modelling and built three financial models for a friend's business" is far more convincing than "I've worked on it."

“I quit before I had another job”

Plenty of people leave without a plan. Burnout, a toxic manager, a move, a family situation, or simply seeing the layoffs coming and getting out first. The worry is that it sounds impulsive.

The key word is *decision*. Frame it as a choice you made deliberately, not something that happened to you.

> *“I decided to leave in the summer. The company was going through a lot of cuts and I wanted to make my next move on my own terms rather than wait. It’s given me the time to be selective, and this is one of only a handful of roles I’ve applied for.”*

Don’t say “I quit because my manager was terrible,” even if they were. You can be honest about the general situation (“the team had a lot of turnover and it wasn’t an environment where I could grow”) without naming villains.

“I left because of burnout or health”

You don’t owe anyone details about your health, mental or physical. You only need to answer the employer’s real question, which is *are you ready to work now?*

> *“I took some time off to deal with a personal matter. That’s fully resolved, and I’m rested and really keen to get back to it.”*

If they push for details, which a good interviewer won’t, you can say: “It was a health matter, and it’s behind me. I’d rather focus on what I can bring to this role.” That’s a complete, polite answer.

“This is my second (or third) layoff”

Two layoffs in a row can feel like a pattern, and you might worry the interviewer will think *this person is always the one cut*. Usually, it’s the industry. Tech, media, retail and startups all go through waves of cuts that hit

good people.

Name the pattern before they do, and then point to what's consistent about *you*.

> *"I've worked in media for most of my career, and both of my last two employers went through big cuts. In both roles, though, I was the one who [built the newsletter from zero / ran the biggest client / trained new hires]. Part of what attracts me here is that you've been growing steadily for years, and I'd love to be somewhere I can build something over the long term."*

"I'm still there, but my job is ending"

This is actually a strong position, and you should present it as one.

> *"My role is being phased out at the end of next month as part of a restructuring. I'm finishing the handover of my accounts, and I wanted to start looking early so I can make a thoughtful move instead of a rushed one."*

"I left a long time ago and did something else in between"

If you were laid off years ago and then freelanced, cared for someone, studied or did odd jobs, the layoff barely matters anymore. Lead with what you did most recently and only mention the layoff if asked. We'll go deeper into this in the next chapter.

5. The gap on your résumé

The longer the job search goes, the more a second worry creeps in: the gap. Every week without a job feels like another mark against you. By month four or five, people start dreading the dates on their résumé almost as much as the layoff itself.

Here's the honest picture. **A gap is mostly a problem if you look uncomfortable about it.** Interviewers want to know two things: what you did with the time, and whether you're ready now.

How long is "long"?

There's no official rule, but this is roughly how a gap tends to be read.

Gap	How it's usually seen	How much to say
Up to 3 months	A normal job search. Often nobody even asks.	One sentence, only if asked.
3 to 6 months	Very common, especially in a slow market.	Reason plus one thing you did.
6 to 12 months	They want to see you kept your skills fresh.	Reason, activity, and why you're ready.
Over 12 months	They want reassurance you're committed and current.	Bring it up yourself, with concrete activities.

The three-sentence gap answer

You'll recognise the shape from Chapter 3.

Why there's a gap. One sentence. "After the layoff, I took a few weeks off and then started a focused search."

What you did with it. One or two sentences. This is where you show you didn't just sit still.

Why you're ready now. One sentence pointing at this job.

> *"After the layoff in May, I took a couple of weeks to reset and then started searching properly. I've been selective, and I've also used the time to get my Google Analytics certification, which I'd wanted to do for a while. So I feel more up to date than when I left, and I'm ready to commit to the right team."*

What counts as "doing something"

People often think they have nothing to show for their gap, when actually they do. Here's what counts, and how to say it.

- **A course or certificate**, even a free one. "I completed a course in project management to fill a gap I'd noticed in my last role."
- **Freelance, contract or cash-in-hand work.** "I did a few freelance bookkeeping jobs for small local businesses." If it was for friends or family, that counts too, as long as it was real work.
- **Volunteering.** "I've been helping a local food bank with their scheduling and stock system." This shows character *and* skills.
- **Caring for someone.** "I was looking after my mother after her surgery. She's doing well now, and I'm fully available." You don't need to say more than that.
- **A personal project.** Building a website, writing, renovating, organising an event. If you can link it to a skill the job needs, mention it.
- **The search itself.** If you've genuinely been searching hard, you can say so. "I've been selective, because I want the next role to be one I stay in" is a perfectly respectable answer.

If you really have nothing to show yet

Start something today. I mean that literally. Sign up for a free online course in your field this evening. Offer to help a friend's small business with something you're good at. Write three LinkedIn posts about what you learned in your last job.

In two weeks you'll be able to say "I'm currently doing X," and it'll be true. That's all it takes. Nobody expects a gap to be a period of heroic productivity. They just want to see that you're moving.

The gap answer for career changers

If you used the gap to switch fields, the gap becomes part of your story rather than a hole in it.

> *"When my role in retail management ended, I decided to move into HR rather than go back to the same thing. I spent the last few months doing an HR fundamentals course and helping a friend's company set up their onboarding process. Ten years of managing store teams gave me a lot of practical people experience, which I think is an advantage in an HR role."*

6. “So, tell me about yourself”

It’s usually the first question. It sounds easy and it isn’t. And for people who’ve been laid off, it hides a trap: **they start with the layoff.**

“Well, I was at Company X for six years until I was laid off in March, so I’m looking for…”

You’ve just made the least interesting thing about you the first thing they hear. The interviewer hasn’t even asked about it yet, and now it’s framing everything else you say.

Don’t do that. The layoff belongs near the end of this answer, in one sentence, or not at all. If they want to know why you left, they’ll ask, and you have your thirty-second answer ready.

Present, past, future

The simplest structure for “tell me about yourself” is three steps.

Present. Who you are, professionally, in a sentence. What you do and what you’re good at.

Past. One or two specific things you’ve done that prove it. Numbers help.

Future. Why this job, now.

Aim for about a minute. Under 45 seconds feels thin. Over two minutes feels like a speech.

An example

> *“I’m a customer success manager. I’ve spent about six years working with mid-sized business clients in software, and what I’m best at is taking unhappy accounts and turning them into long-term customers. At my last company I looked after about forty accounts, and over a year we brought our churn down from 14% to 8%, mostly by starting regular check-ins nobody had been doing before. That role ended when the company cut its European team in the summer. Since then I’ve been focusing on roles where retention is a real priority, and from what I’ve read about your plans for next year, it’s a big one here.”*

The layoff is there. It’s one sentence. It’s sandwiched between an achievement and a reason for wanting this job. That’s exactly where it belongs.

What to leave out

- Your whole career history, year by year. They have your résumé.
- Where you grew up, your hobbies, your family (unless it connects directly to the job).
- Anything negative about any employer.
- Weaknesses, doubts, or “I’m not sure if I’m the right fit, but…”
- The details of the layoff.

If you’re changing careers

Lead with the *skill* that carries over, not the old job title.

Instead of: “I’ve been a teacher for eight years, but I’m trying to get into corporate training.”

Try: “I design and deliver training. For the last eight years I’ve done that as a secondary school teacher, planning lessons for 150 students a year and training new teachers in our department. I’ve realised the part I enjoy most is the

training design itself, so I've been moving into corporate learning, and I recently built a full onboarding course for a local business as a project."

Same person. One version sounds like someone running away from something. The other sounds like someone running towards something.

7. Getting your confidence back before you walk in

You can have perfect answers on paper and still walk into the room feeling small. A few weeks of silence from employers will do that to anyone. So before we go further into questions and answers, let's work on the person who's going to be giving them.

Confidence before an interview isn't a personality trait. It's mostly preparation plus evidence. You can build both.

Build a "proof file"

Open a document or grab a notebook and write down everything you've achieved at work. Not your job duties. Things that happened *because you were there*.

Some questions to get you going:

- What problem did you fix that had been bothering people for a while?
- When did a customer, colleague or manager thank you for something specific?
- What numbers improved while you were responsible for them? Sales, time, costs, errors, complaints, sign-ups.
- Who did you train or help get better?
- What would have gone worse if you hadn't been there?

Write at least ten. It'll feel hard at first and then it'll start flowing. These become the raw material for your stories (Chapter 8) and your "tell me about yourself" answer. But they also do something else: they remind you, in black and white, that you were good at your job. Read the list the morning of your interview.

Prepare your stories, not just your answers

Most interviews include "tell me about a time when…" questions. A time you handled conflict. A time you failed. A time you worked under pressure. People panic on these because they try to come up with a story on the spot.

You don't have to. If you prepare **six or seven good stories** from your proof file, you can adapt them to almost any question. One story about a big achievement might answer "your proudest moment," "a time you went above and beyond" and "a time you showed initiative."

For each story, jot down four things:

- **The situation.** Where were you, what was going on? One or two sentences.
- **Your task.** What were you responsible for?
- **What you did.** This is the biggest part. Use "I," not "we." What exactly did *you* do?
- **The result.** What changed? A number is best. A clear outcome is fine.

That structure is often called STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result), and interviewers know it well. Spoken out loud, each story should take about a minute and a half.

There are story worksheets in the Toolkit.

Record yourself (yes, really)

This is the exercise everyone skips and the one that helps most.

Put your phone on the table. Hit record. Ask yourself the three big questions out loud: “Tell me about yourself,” “Why did you leave your last job?” and one “tell me about a time” question. Answer each one as if the interviewer were sitting across from you.

Then listen back once. Just once. You’re listening for three things:

- **Length.** Was the layoff answer under 30 seconds? Was “tell me about yourself” under two minutes?
- **Filler.** Did you start with “so, um, basically”?
- **Tone.** Did your voice change when you talked about your old job?

Fix one thing, record again. Most people need three or four rounds before it sounds natural. It’s uncomfortable to hear yourself. It’s much more uncomfortable to hear yourself ramble in the actual interview.

Look after the basics

This sounds obvious, but after weeks of job searching, a lot of people are running on bad sleep, irregular meals and too much screen time. You think more clearly when you’ve slept. You sound calmer when you’ve eaten. You have more energy when you’ve been outside that day. None of it is complicated, and all of it shows up in an interview.

8. The follow-up questions that trip people up

You've given your thirty-second answer. It went well. Then they ask a follow-up, and that's where unprepared people come undone. Here are the follow-ups that come up most for laid-off candidates, what's really being asked, and how to answer.

"Why do you think they chose you?"

What they're really asking: Was it performance?

Don't guess and don't get defensive. Give the real criteria if you know them, and offer evidence.

> *"It was based on which projects the company kept. Mine was in the area they closed. My last two reviews were strong, and my former manager is happy to be a reference."*

"Were you a low performer?"

Rarely asked this bluntly, but it happens.

> *"No, and I'm happy for you to check. In my last year I [specific result]. The decision was about the budget for our department, not individual performance."*

Keep your voice level. The question isn't an accusation. It's a box they need to tick.

"How do you feel about your old company?"

What they're really asking: Will you be negative about us one day too?

> *"Honestly, mostly grateful. I learned a lot there, especially about [skill]. Nobody enjoys a layoff, but I understand why they did it."*

Even if you don't feel grateful yet, there's probably *something* you learned there. Lead with that.

"What have you been doing since you left?"

You've already prepared for this in Chapter 5. Give your activities, briefly.

> *"Three things, mainly. A focused job search, a course in [subject] that I'd been meaning to take, and some freelance work for a couple of small businesses, which kept me sharp."*

"Why do you want this job?"

What they're really asking: Do you actually want *this* job, or just *a* job?

This is where research pays off. Say something specific about the role or the company that you couldn't say about any other.

> *"Two things stood out. The role is mostly about improving the onboarding process, which is the part of my last job I enjoyed most. And you're expanding into Germany next year, and I've managed German-speaking customers before."*

"Why should we hire you?"

Match your strongest proof to their biggest need.

> *“From the job description and what you’ve told me today, your biggest challenge is [their problem]. I’ve solved that before: at my last company I [specific result]. And I’m available now, so I could start making a difference quickly.”*

“Tell me about a time you failed.”

Don’t use the layoff as your failure. It wasn’t your failure, and it pulls the conversation back to the topic you want to keep short. Pick a real work mistake, show how you handled it, and what you do differently now.

> *“Early in my last role, I underestimated how long a data migration would take, and we missed the first deadline by two weeks. I told my manager as soon as I realised, re-planned it with the team, and we delivered the rest on time. Since then I always build in a buffer and flag risks in the first week, not the last.”*

“Tell me about a conflict.”

Choose a story where you disagreed with someone, handled it like an adult, and the outcome was good. Avoid stories where the other person was simply a villain.

> *“A colleague in finance and I disagreed about how to report returns. Instead of escalating, I asked her for half an hour to understand her side. It turned out the auditors needed it a certain way, which I hadn’t known. We agreed on a format that worked for both teams, and it became the standard.”*

“What’s your biggest weakness?”

Choose something real but not central to the job, and show what you’re doing about it.

> *“I tend to take too much on myself instead of delegating. On a big project last year that slowed us down, so I started breaking tasks out at the start and assigning them in our first meeting. I’m much better at it now, though I still have to remind myself.”*

“Where do you see yourself in five years?”

What they’re really asking: Will you stay, or leave the moment something better comes up?

> *“Growing here, ideally. Getting really good at [area] and taking on more responsibility, maybe training newer people. After the last year, I’m looking for somewhere I can build something long-term.”*

“Do you have other interviews going on?”

Be honest, and turn it into interest.

If yes: “I’m talking to a couple of other companies, but this one is my first choice because [reason].”

If no: “I’ve been quite selective, and this is one of the few roles I’ve really gone after.”

9. How not to sound desperate (even if you are)

Let's be honest. If you've been out of work for a few months, you might *be* a bit desperate. The savings are going down. You're doing maths at the kitchen table. Every interview feels like it has to work.

That's real, and there's nothing wrong with feeling it. The problem is when it leaks into the interview, because desperation makes interviewers nervous. It suggests you'd take any job, which suggests you might leave as soon as a better one comes along. It also tends to make people undersell themselves.

Here's how it usually shows up, and what to do instead.

The words

Instead of	Try
"I really need this job."	"I'm really interested in this role."
"I'll take anything."	"I've been selective, and this one stood out because..."
"I'm flexible on everything."	"I'm flexible on [specific thing], and what matters most to me is [thing]."
"Sorry, I'm a bit nervous."	Just take a breath. Nobody needs the commentary.
"I know I've been out of work for a while, but..."	Don't bring it up. If they ask, use your gap answer.
"I was just doing my job."	"I [action] and it [result]."

Salary

This is where desperation costs you actual money. The instinct is to name a low number so you don't price yourself out. Resist it.

Do your homework before the interview. Look up the typical salary range for this role in your area on job sites, salary comparison sites, or by looking at similar job ads. Then, if they ask, give a range based on the market, not on your fear.

> *"Based on what I've seen for similar roles in this area, I'm looking at roughly [range]. I'm open to discussing it depending on the whole package."*

If your last job paid more and this one pays less, and you're fine with that, say why.

> *"I know it's a bit below what I was earning before. I'm comfortable with that because [the role is what I want / the stability matters more to me now / there's room to grow here]."*

The energy

Desperation often looks like overcompensating. Talking too fast, agreeing with everything, laughing too hard, saying yes before they've finished the question. Slow down. Pause before you answer. It's fine to say "That's a good question, let me think for a second." Calm reads as competent.

Remember you're choosing too

The best mindset shift I know is this: **you're interviewing them as well.** You're about to spend forty hours a week there. You deserve to know if it's a good place to work. Prepare real questions (there's a list in the Toolkit) and ask them as if the answers matter to you. Because they do.

10. Interview day

You've done the thinking. Now it's about not letting small practical things trip you up.

The evening before

- Read the job description one more time and highlight the three things they seem to care about most.
- Read your notes on the company. Know what they do, roughly how big they are, and one recent piece of news.
- Say your three key answers out loud once each: "tell me about yourself," your layoff answer, your gap answer if you have one.
- Choose three questions to ask them.
- Lay out your clothes. Aim for one step more formal than what people at the company wear day to day.
- Check the route and leave room for delays. For a video call, test the link.
- Go to bed at a normal time. Last-minute cramming makes you tired, not prepared.

The morning of

- Eat something, even if you're not hungry.
- Read your proof file. Just the list. Let it remind you who you are.
- Arrive about ten minutes early. Not thirty. Sitting in reception for half an hour does nobody's nerves any good.

In the room

- Greet everyone, use their names, and make eye contact.
- When you get a question, it's fine to pause. A two-second pause looks thoughtful.
- Keep your layoff answer short and then stop talking.
- If you go blank, say so lightly: "Sorry, let me start that again." It happens to everyone and almost nobody minds.
- Take a notebook. Writing down a key point while they talk shows you're listening, and it gives you something to do with your hands.

Video interviews

Video interviews are now completely normal, and they have their own small traps.

- Put the camera at eye level. A stack of books under a laptop works fine.
- Sit facing a window or a lamp, not with light behind you.
- Clear the background or use a plain wall. Avoid fake backgrounds if they glitch around your head.
- Close every other app and turn off notifications.
- Look at the camera when you're talking, not at your own face on screen.
- Have your phone's hotspot ready in case your internet drops.
- A sticky note with three keywords next to the camera is fine. A full script on screen is not. People can see your eyes reading.

Recorded video interviews

Some companies send a link where you record answers to questions on your own, with no person on the other end. They feel strange, but the same rules apply. Use the practice question if there is one. Keep answers to about a minute or a minute and a half. Smile at the start of each answer. A real person will watch it later, even if it doesn't feel that way.

11. After the interview

You walk out, and your brain immediately starts replaying everything you said wrong. That's normal. Let it run for ten minutes, then do something useful with it.

Write down what happened

While it's fresh, note down which questions surprised you, which answers went well, and which you'd change. Every interview is practice for the next one. People who keep these notes get noticeably better within three or four interviews.

Send a thank-you email the same day

It's a small thing that a surprising number of candidates skip. Keep it short, mention one specific thing from the conversation, and restate why you're a good fit. There's a template in the Toolkit.

While you wait

Don't stop applying because one interview went well. This is the most common mistake people make, and it can cost weeks. Keep your search going until you've signed an offer.

If they gave you a date and it passes with no word, wait two or three working days and send a polite follow-up. One follow-up is professional. Five is not.

If you get a “no”

It’s going to happen. It happens to everyone, including people who eventually land great jobs. A rejection usually means someone else fit a bit better on that day, not that something is wrong with you.

Reply to the rejection. Thank them, say you enjoyed meeting them, and ask if they have any feedback. Most won’t give much, but some will, and occasionally a company will come back months later when another role opens. You’d be surprised how often the person who replied graciously is remembered.

Then go back to your notes, adjust one thing, and get ready for the next one.

A last word

When you've been laid off, it's easy to feel that this one event is the whole story of your working life right now. It isn't. It's one sentence in a much longer story, and you get to decide how much space that sentence takes up.

In your next interview, say it calmly. Say it in thirty seconds. Then spend the rest of the time talking about what you've done, what you're good at, and what you want to do next. That's the part of the story that gets people hired.

You've done hard things at work before. You've got a list of them now. Go and add another one.

Good luck. You've got this.

Toolkit

Everything in this section is meant to be printed and written on, or filled in on your tablet. Use a pencil. You'll change your answers as you practise, and that's the point.

Worksheet 1: My proof file

Write down ten things that happened at work *because you were there*. Results, fixes, thank-yous, people you helped. (Chapter 7)

Worksheet 2: My 30-second layoff answer

(Chapter 3)

1. What happened (one plain sentence, no warm-up)

2. Why it wasn't about me (scale of the layoff, or one specific result)

3. Where I'm going now (why this kind of role, why this company)

☐ Under 30 seconds out loud ☐ No blame ☐ No apology ☐ Ends on the future ☐ Practised 5 times

Worksheet 3: My gap answer

(Chapter 5) Skip this if your gap is under three months.

Why there's a gap

What I did with the time (courses, freelance, volunteering, caring, projects, the search)

Why I'm ready now

Worksheet 4: "Tell me about yourself"

(Chapter 6) Aim for about one minute.

Present: I'm a... and what I'm best at is...

Past: One or two results that prove it (numbers if you can)

Future: Why this role, why now

Worksheet 5: My story bank

(Chapter 7) Six stories cover most “tell me about a time when…” questions.

Story 1: A big achievement. *Use for: proudest moment, initiative, why hire you.*

Situation and task:

What I did:

Result:

Story 2: A problem solved under pressure. *Use for: stress, deadlines, a difficult situation.*

Situation and task:

What I did:

Result:

Story 3: A conflict or disagreement. *Use for: teamwork, a difficult colleague, disagreeing with a manager.*

Situation and task:

What I did:

Result:

Story 4: A mistake I learned from. *Use for: failure, weakness, feedback.*

Situation and task:

What I did:

Result and lesson:

Story 5: Dealing with change. *Use for: adapting, uncertainty, restructuring. (Very useful for you.)*

Situation and task:

What I did:

Result:

Story 6: Helping a customer or colleague. *Use for: customer focus, teamwork, going the extra mile.*

Situation and task:

What I did:

Result:

Questions to ask them

Pick two or three. Good questions show you're choosing them too.

About the role

1. What would a great first three months look like in this role?
2. What's the biggest challenge the person in this job will face?
3. Is this a new position, or is it replacing someone?

About the team and company

4. How would you describe the team I'd be working with?
5. What are the company's main priorities for the next year?
6. How has the team changed over the last year or so?
7. What do the people who do really well here have in common?

About growth

8. How do people usually develop or move on from this role?
9. What kind of training or support is there?

To close

10. Is there anything about my background that makes you hesitate? I'd like the chance to address it.
11. What are the next steps, and when can I expect to hear from you?

Avoid in a first interview: asking only about salary, holidays or working from home, asking something that's on the first page of their website, or saying "No, I think you've covered everything."

Email templates

Thank-you email (send the same day)

Subject: Thank you, [job title] interview

Hi [name],

Thank you for meeting with me today about the [job title] role. I really enjoyed hearing about [something specific from the conversation].

It confirmed how interested I am. I think my experience with [relevant skill or result] would help with [challenge they mentioned].

If there's anything else you need from me, just let me know. I look forward to hearing about the next steps.

Best regards, [your name]

Follow-up (if the date they gave you has passed)

Subject: Following up, [job title]

Hi [name],

I hope you're well. I wanted to follow up on my interview on [date] for the [job title] role. I'm still very interested and happy to provide anything else you need.

Do you have an update on the timeline?

Kind regards, [your name]

After a rejection (keep the door open)

Subject: Re: [job title]

Hi [name],

Thanks for letting me know, and for the time you and the team spent with me. I enjoyed learning about [company], and I'd be glad to be considered for future roles.

If you have a moment, I'd really appreciate any feedback that could help me in my search.

All the best, [your name]

Cut-out cheat sheet

Read this in the car park, on the train, or five minutes before the video call.

The layoff answer: what happened, why it wasn't about me, where I'm going. 30 seconds. Then stop talking.

The gap: why, what I did, why I'm ready now.

Tell me about yourself: present, past, future. About a minute. The layoff is one sentence near the end, or not at all.

Stories: situation, task, what *I* did, result. Use numbers.

Never: blame my old employer, apologise for being laid off, say "I'll take anything," guess why they chose me.

Always: pause before answering, be specific, end on the future, ask them two good questions.

Salary: a range based on research, not on fear.

Afterwards: notes, thank-you email today, keep applying.

I was good at my job before. I'm still good at it now.